

[The Gospel Network](#)

Christ Our Sin Bearer: The Lamb Of God



Christ Our Sin Bearer: The Lamb Of God

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Content

[Introduction](#)

[One --- Confounding Easter](#)

[Two --- Christ Our Sin Bearer](#)

[Three ---Jesus Paid It All](#)

[Four --- Christ Our Passover Lamb](#)

[Five --- Christ And Him Crucified](#)

[Six --- The King Is Risen](#)

[Seven---The Certainty Of The Resurrection](#)

INTRODUCTION

Easter is a period Christians commemorate the death of Christ universally. Despite its universality, just like Christmas, Easter means different things to different people, who might even call themselves Christians.

However we may feel towards it, the death and resurrection of Christ is an historical event. He lived as a human being, died, resurrected and ascended to heaven

The articles which follow are blog posts from *www.thegospelnetworkgh.com* and other sources compiled pointing to the significance of the season — Jesus Christ's death and resurrection for the salvation of sinners.

I pray this e-book blesses you

Soli Deo Gloria!

Kwesi Sena

The Gospel Network

ONE
POEM: CONFOUNDING EASTER
By [Theo Aryee](#)

- 1: Royal blood for a commoner
Strange kingdom
 2. Potter broken to fix the pot
Weird order
 3. Eternity curtailed for mortality
Ever seen a pregnant infant?
 4. Well runs dry so community can begin to
quench their thirst
Rain falls from the ground up
 5. The guilty kills the guiltless
The zenith of wickedness
 6. The guiltless dies for, and at the hands of, the
guilty, to make them guiltless.
Purest love
 7. Creation abuses the creator
Jungle justice
 8. Foulest mouth spits on holy face
Sacriligious abuse
 9. Darkness dispels light
Evil triumphs
 10. Life dies
The end
- No ! The beginning

TWO

CHRIST OUR SIN BEARER

By Enoch A. Anti, Read [Online](#)

Genesis is the first book of the Bible. It is also the book of beginnings because it tells us the origins of life and accurately explains the main problem of the world—Sin. From the first two chapters of Genesis, we are told of a Creator —God— Who created the world and all that dwells in it (Genesis 1:1, 31, 2:26-27). After creation, God saw that everything He had created was good (Genesis 1:31).

But today, in contrast to Genesis 1:31, the world in its current state is not good. It is a world filled with pain, tragedy, wickedness, cruelty and every horror imaginable. How do we reconcile the current state of the world with God’s proclamation that “everything that he had made...was very good”. The answer is that sin entered the world. So;

What Is Sin?

Sin is any want of conformity unto, or transgression of, the law of God [a]. Lev 5:17; Jas 4:17;

1 John 3:4

~Westminster Shorter Catechism Q14

In these words we see what sin is. Sin is breaking God’s law by omission or commission. In modern English, the words, “want of conformity” will read as “inability to conform to the law of God” or “failure to measure up to or obey God’s command”.

In Greek, the word *hamartia* is used in explaining what sin is. Sin is “*missing the mark*” just like when an archer or bowman misses their target. And rightly so, we are all sinners because we have missed the mark of God’s righteous standard (Romans 3:23).

How did sin enter the perfect world God created one may ask? Again, we turn to the book of origins. In Genesis 2:16-17, we read of a commandment God gave Adam, the first created man, “And the LORD God commanded the man, saying, “You may surely eat of every tree of the garden, but of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat of it you shall surely die”.

Fast forward to Genesis 3, Adam disobeyed God; he ate of the forbidden tree and by that act of disobedience, sin entered the world. Adam in the garden of Eden was acting as a federal head for all of humankind therefore his fall became the fall of all who will ever walk this earth: “Therefore, just as sin came into the world through one man, and death through sin, and so death spread to all men because all sinned”(Romans 5:12).

Except Jesus who lived a perfect life without sin, all humankind inherited the consequences and effects of Adam’s fall; physical and spiritual death. Our nature was badly corrupted and we were alienated from God. The Psalmist said “Behold, I was

brought forth in iniquity, and in sin did my mother conceive me” (Psalm 51:5).

What he means here is that he was born with a sin problem. He inherited sin. We are by ourselves unable to please God: “None is righteous, no, not one; no one understands; no one seeks God. All have turned aside; together they have become worthless; no one does good, not even one.” (Romans 3:11-12). These words describe the helpless state of humankind without Christ. They are enemies of God, separated from Him and guilty of eternal damnation.

However God didn’t leave sinners to our fate to try to work our way to Him. God made the first move towards reconciling sinful humankind to Himself. If you read Genesis 3 again, we see that though Adam and Eve sinned, God’s mercy was manifested.

Firstly, God proclaimed what theologians refer to as [protoevangelium](#)—the first gospel. God announced His plans towards reconciliation. A curse was pronounced and a remedy for that curse was also revealed: “I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and her offspring; he shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel” (Genesis 3:15).

The seed of the woman referred to here is Christ who the Bible speaks of by saying “The reason the Son of God appeared was to destroy the works of the devil”(1 John 3:8). The works of the devil is sin

that separated us from God. And it is this, Jesus died to destroy. He took the punishment that belonged to sinners. He died in our place to appease for our sins and reconcile us to the Father. Our sin was imputed to Him. He became our substitutionary atonement (Isaiah 53:5-6, John 1:29).

Secondly, God covered the nakedness (guilt and shame) of Adam and Eve revealing a type of Christ's imputed righteousness to those who will come to Faith through Jesus Christ (Genesis 3:21). Paul aptly captures this saying, "For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God" (2Corinthians 5:21).

Christ was murdered on the cross because of the sins of you and I. And He resurrected to give eternal life to all who will come to Him in Faith. This is the essence of what we celebrate as Easter. Christ dying for the sins of the world (John1:29). If you have not come to saving faith through Christ, you are condemned to eternal damnation and an enemy of God. One day, you will have to answer for your sins before a Holy God and nothing you will present will measure up to God's Holy standard. Your good works outside of Christ are like filthy rags. Repent from your sins and turn to Christ for forgiveness.

THREE JESUS PAID IT ALL

By Ebenezer Forster-Nyarko, Read [Online](#)

Romans 10:3-9

*Jesus paid it all,
All to Him I owe;
Sin had left a crimson stain,
He washed it white as snow.
~ Elvina M. Hall; 1865*

Imagine this scenario with me. A man who owes the creditors a huge sum of money is dragged before the court. He admits that even if all his property were sold, it wouldn't be enough to clear all his debt. Suddenly, a 'good Samaritan' offers to settle all the debt to the last penny. If it were you, what would be your reaction? Now imagine further, if instead of accepting the good Samaritan's benevolent offer, this debtor rejects it; choosing rather to make up for his debt by suffering a lifetime of hard labour in prison.

Who would do such a thing? Sounds outrageous doesn't it? Yet in the passage from Romans 10 above, Paul suggests the actions of the Jews amounted to just that. They, to whom God gave the Law had spurned God's Son, Jesus Christ, and rejected His offer of salvation through faith. In his description, Paul writes, "For, being ignorant of the righteousness of God, and seeking to establish their own, they did not submit to God's righteousness"

(Romans 10:3). The phrase “seeking to establish their own righteousness” (in the authorized translation, “going about to establish their own righteousness”) connotes a strenuous effort to establish one’s own righteousness instead of relying on God’s.

The Law and Man’s Inability

God gave the Law to man with this caveat “...the person who does the commandments shall live by them.” (Romans 10:5b). Which means one could attain righteousness and eternal life by fully obeying the law without faulting at any point (Deuteronomy 30:15-20, James 2:10). In our fallen state, God’s verdict is that no one could keep the law no matter how hard we try. The Jews were therefore wrong in thinking that they could work out their own righteousness before a holy and perfect God. God requires sinless perfection. Jesus in Matthew 5:20-48 clearly teaches that the benchmark is not 99% but a 100%.

It is therefore tragic that anyone would try to attain righteousness by their own effort and good works. Many today go to great lengths to be good, fast, pray and obey the 10 commandments — all in an attempt to save themselves. God demands perfect obedience with all of one’s heart, mind, soul and strength, and one ought to continue doing so unflinchingly in order to maintain righteousness (Matt 22:36-38; Rom 10:5). The plain truth is that none of us is equal to such a task.

The law points to the fact that we need God's help in order to be saved. It shows us how inadequate we are in terms of fulfilling God's Law; yet offers us no remedy. On this, John Bunyan writes, *"To be under the law as it is a Covenant of Works, is to be bound, upon pain of eternal damnation, to fulfil, and that completely and continually, every particular point of the Ten Commandments, by doing them."*¹

Paul, recounting his own experience wrote:

For I do not understand my own actions. For I do not do what I want, but I do the very thing I hate. Now if I do what I do not want, I agree with the law, that it is good. For I know that nothing good dwells in me, that is, in my flesh. For I have the desire to do what is right, but not the ability to carry it out. Wretched man that I am! Who will deliver me from this body of death? Thanks be to God through Jesus Christ our Lord! (Romans 7:15-16, 18, 24-25a ESV).

John Bunyan further comments,

So long as people are ignorant of the nature of the law, and of their being under it – that is, under the curse and condemning power of it, by reason of their sin against it – so long they will be careless,

¹ John Bunyan, *The Doctrine of the Law and Grace Unfolded*, (PDF accessed from www.Chapellibrary.org/book/budotl/doctrine-of-the-law-and-grace-unfolded) P.12

and negligent as to the inquiring after the true knowledge of the Gospel.”¹

If we truly understood what the law required of us in order to be saved, we’ll come flying to the foot of the Cross.

The Good News: Christ, The End of the Law

Jesus, as the last Adam, was the only one who was able to wholly and completely obey God’s Law. This is what Paul meant by saying Christ is the end of the Law. Not that He abolished it; but rather because He fulfilled all its righteous requirements. But He is the end of the Law only to those who believe in Him. To these, the law is no longer binding in justifying sinners before Christ. Through faith in the finished work of Christ, sinners are freed from the guilt of the Law and from God’s wrath. Christ’s life of sinless obedience and His death on the cross fully satisfied God’s wrath against sin for all who believe in Him.

God therefore offers righteousness to all who believe in Christ alone, free of charge. This does not require any strenuous effort from us — only faith in Christ and what He has done on our behalf.

¹ John Bunyan, *The Doctrine of the Law and Grace*

Unfolded(PDF accessed from

www.Chapellibrary.org/book/budotl/doctrine-of-the-law-and-grace-unfolded) P.3

There's no need to strenuously seek to establish your own righteousness. Jesus paid it all — all the debt we owed God for disobeying His Holy Law and its repercussions; eternal death. This is the reason for the Cross. Celebrate this season with understanding. If you haven't already, come to saving faith in Christ now; He is willing and ready to save you.

FOUR
CHRIST OUR PASSOVER LAMB
By Enoch A. Anti, Read [Online](#)

[John 2:13-22](#)

It was a religious festival with crowds of worshippers. Everything was going well. All the worshippers needed for worship was available for sale in the corridors of the temple: one stop shop it was. The sheep are bleating. Doves in cages are flapping their wings. People have gathered from different parts of the world. So there was a ready forex bureau....then comes in a young man tipping tables over and driving people away from the temple.

By now you may have identified with this story. The scene is Jerusalem in the temple. Jesus drove out people selling in the temple and makes some astonishing statements: “Destroy this temple and in three days I will raise it up” (v.19). This is a temple that has taken forty-six years to build so with equal astonishment, the Jews responded: “It has taken forty-six years to build this temple, and you will raise it up in three days? (v.20).

Have you ever been in a conversation only to realise the other party has been misunderstanding all you have been saying? Here is a perfect example. The Scripture tells us Christ “...was speaking about the temple of his body” (v.21). Jesus is God tabernacled on earth. He was speaking spiritually about His

death and resurrection, but the Jews were thinking of the physical temple.

There are a number of lessons here to draw on.

Firstly, all of these incidents took place during the *Passover celebration*. Verse 13 of John 2 tells us “The Passover of the Jews was at hand and Jesus went up to Jerusalem.” There are at least two questions here to be answered:

- What Is The Passover?
- Why Did Jesus Go To Jerusalem?

What Is The Passover?

[Exodus 12:1-4](#)

The Passover is one of a number of Jewish festivals commanded by God to be commemorated by the Jews. It marks the story of the angel of death passing over Israel but killing all the first born male children of every Egyptian and beast. This was the last of 10 plagues brought upon the Egyptians and Pharaoh finally allowed the Israelites to leave Egypt.

Why Did Jesus Go To Jerusalem?

The answer is two-fold. He was a Jew and He went to observe or celebrate the Passover as commanded by God. Jerusalem was the place of worship where God institute the commemoration of the Passover

(see Luke 2:42, John 4:20, Acts 8:26-27).

In the temple, at Jerusalem, the events of the day had significance. Jesus “found those who were selling oxen and sheep, and the money-changers sitting there (v.14). It must be noted that during the festival, people from different parts of the then world converge at Jerusalem to worship. Considering the things needed for the festival, animals for sacrifices and etc., it will be cumbersome to carry along all the things needed in a journey. So the oxen, sheep and pigeon on sale were all important. The money changers also had a special place in the then world. Most importantly, every Jewish male 20years or older (Exodus 30:11-16) was required to pay a temple tax so the money changers offer “forex bureau” services to the travellers.

Now, the merchants were engaged in worship-distracting activity. Worship is to be reverential and in spirit and in truth (John 4:4, Matthew 21:13) but the worshippers had made it a house of trade: Do not make my father’s house a house of trade” (John 2:16).

You may ask, “What has all these got to do with my life as a Christian? To this I turn to three applications:

What The Passover Lamb Was To The Jew, Christ Is To The Christian

The lamb slain for the Passover is a *type* of Christ and what a glorious moment to speak of His death and resurrection at the Passover celebrations. Just as the Angel of death passed over the Israelites, as Christians, we have passed from death to life by the sacrifice of Christ. We have been delivered from the bondage of sin and translated into the Kingdom of Christ. We have been pardoned of all our sins. We have been quickened and raised to sit in heavenly places with Christ (Ephesians 2:1).

What Was Required Of Temple Worship Is Required Of The Believer

The cleansing of the physical temple gives us some lessons of what is required of our spiritual temple (1Corinthians 3:23, 2Corinthians 6:16-18). Our body is the temple of God and anything we do to dishonour the temple of God dishonours Christ. Our lives must be marked by holiness and reverence (Romans 12:1-2, Psalm 69:9).

What The Passover Celebrations Was To The Jews, The Lord Supper Is To The Christian

Just as the Passover celebration is a commemoration of the Passover, Christ instituted the Lord's Supper for the believer to remember his death till he come: "Do this in remembrance of me." (Luke 22:19).

FIVE
CHRIST AND HIM CRUCIFIED
By Ebenezer Forster-Nyarko, [Read Online](#) *

[1 Thessalonians 1:5-10](#)

If the preaching of the Gospel is to have any effect in the lives of its hearers, it needs to come in power, in the Holy Spirit and with full conviction. In our opening verses, the apostle lets us in on the reason the call of the Gospel is effectual in those who believe it. To these people, the Gospel comes in full conviction, as a result of the mighty work of the Holy Spirit in their hearts. It does not rest on human wisdom or eloquence.

Paul wrote elsewhere in a parallel verse saying, “my speech and my message were not in plausible words of wisdom, but in demonstration of the Spirit and of power,” and then he explained why: “so that your faith might not rest in the wisdom of men but in the power of God.” (1 Corinthians 2:4-5). Faithful Gospel preaching is Christ-centered and Christ-exulting. Paul writing few verses earlier in 1Cor 2 had this to say: “For I decided to know nothing among you except Jesus Christ and him crucified. And I was with you in weakness and in fear and much trembling,” (1 Corinthians 2:2-3).

Here we find one unique characteristic of Gospel preaching as taught in the New Testament; it does not draw attention to the preacher, but to Christ, and His resurrection. The manner of life of the apostles

among those whom the Lord sent was that which sought to magnify Christ, and make less of themselves. They were “in weakness and in fear and much trembling,” — clearly desiring that nothing in them will get in the way of their making Christ exulted above all. Paul was therefore bold to remind the Corinthian Christians of the kind of life they lived whilst amongst them — one that sought to make solely Christ and His death on the cross known to all.

Nothing except Christ and Him crucified

The message of the cross is the heart of all that God has done for the salvation of men; and the one thing that must be preached at all times. If our messages don't emphasize this, it falls short of Gospel preaching.

What does it mean for the apostle to preach Christ and Him crucified?

These two things are absolutely crucial – The person of the Lord Jesus Christ, and His Work. To make Jesus Christ known is to preach His person – His incarnation, life, death and resurrection – in order to reconcile fallen man back to God. God came in the flesh in the person of the Lord Jesus Christ. The son of man (Christ); the second person in the Holy Trinity came to seek and to save that which was lost. He only could fulfill the righteous demands of God's holy law by his life of perfect obedience and unlock for us the gates of heaven.

It is tragic that many preachers can teach on Salvation without mentioning the person and the work of the Lord Jesus Christ! But it takes only the God-man to do this. It is His atoning work, His death on the cross and His resurrection that paid the price for our Salvation. This is why Paul sought to make Christ's work and His death known, with fear and trembling. This was the first thing he and the other apostles preached:

Now I would remind you, brothers, of the gospel I preached to you, which you received, in which you stand, and by which you are being saved, if you hold fast to the word I preached to you—unless you believed in vain. For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures (1Corinthians 15:1-4).

His words in the passage above are very instructive: he delivered to them as of first importance, the Gospel! He did not put anything before it. Isn't it a travesty that we ever so often do exactly opposite that – place other things before the Gospel? Christ died for our sins! He was buried and raised on the third day so that we might be forgiven! If you have not come to terms with and believed this, then you are lost and not saved.

You cannot believe in the gospel unless you first believe in the doctrine of the wrath of God against

sin! His death on the cross was a substitution for our sins. He died for you and me! Why did he die for us? Because of what is true about you and me! The Biblical truth is that we are all fallen creatures! This is universally true of everybody, and we are under the wrath of God! (Romans 1:18).

But how can I know that Christ's death was sufficient to atone for my sins and the wrath of God? Because God raised Him from the dead! The Bible is careful to say that God raised Him (Jesus) from the dead – to prove that His death was sufficient once and forever to satisfy God's wrath and the requirement of the law! Romans 4:24-25 is re-assuring in this regard: "...It will be counted to us who believe in him who raised from the dead Jesus our Lord, 25 who was delivered up for our trespasses and raised for our justification."

The Results of Faithful Preaching

Not founded on human efforts, the result of faithful preaching is equally divine and spiritual. Faithful Gospel preaching produces converts who are truly Christ-like.

When the apostles preached faithfully, the results were disciples who imitated The Lord Jesus Christ; full of joy in the Holy Ghost, even in much persecution. Their preaching produced saints who turned from idols to serve the living God, and lived their lives in hope of the second coming of Jesus Christ. The testimony of exemplary Christian living of the Thessalonian Christians, as recorded in our

opening passage, was reported as far as to Macedonia and Archaia.

How does this compare to what pertains in our day? Do we emphasize the cross in our messages? Is Christ and His work truly at the center of our sermons? Do we seek to present the Gospel in the power of the Holy Spirit or do we rely on our eloquence and charisma to ‘move’ our hearers? Do we seek God’s face in tears and humility for the salvation of souls? Could the state of Christianity as we have it today be a reflection of the dearth of faithful Gospel preaching?

My prayer is that God will grant us faithful teachers who will seek nothing except to know Christ and to make Him known. And may God grant that our generation will be filled with faithful Christians whose lives will model the Gospel wherever they find themselves — that others seeing our good works will come to the saving knowledge of Our Lord Jesus Christ. Amen.

*Online article is titled Faithful Preaching: Christ and Him Crucified

SIX THE KING IS RISEN

By Kwesi Sena, Read [Online](#)

[1 Corinthians 15:19-22](#)

On Easter Sunday, Christians all over the world gather to celebrate the resurrection. It is the day our hope in Christ was secured. The grave could not hold the Lion of the tribe of Judah, he defeated death and therein is our hope.

In Luke 24, there is a story about two disciples on their way to Emmaus when Jesus joined them. They were lamenting over their dashed hope of the deliverance of Israel. They longed for deliverance from Roman rule through Christ. However, Christ their deliverer a few days ago was brutally murdered on a cross—the most humiliating way to die. With His death, went their hopes. But as the narrative progresses, we see a hope that is higher than deliverance from Roman oppression. They encountered the Resurrected Christ. He is alive! The grave couldn't hold Him.

The believer's hope is tied to the resurrection of Christ. It is a hope that is beyond the grave. Hope that makes us endure suffering because we know the glory that awaits us. The hope that made Paul count all his achievements as garbage.

What is this hope?

Paul gives us a hint in 1 Corinthians 15:19-22: “If in Christ we have hope in this life only, we are of all people most to be pitied. But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead, the first fruits of those who have fallen asleep. For as by a man came death, by a man has come also the resurrection of the dead. For as in Adam all die, so also in Christ shall all be made alive.”

In this passage Paul was responding to those who deny the resurrection of the dead. He started by saying if there is no resurrection of the dead, then among all people we are the most to be pitied as Christians. He points to Christ’s resurrection as the basis for his certainty. Christ is the first fruit, and once you have the first fruit it signifies that the rest of the harvest is going to come in.

This is the Christian’s hope, it is the hope that our present life is not the end of the story. The hope that our mortal bodies will be changed to the same glorious body of Christ. The hope that God is going to wipe away every tear from our eyes — there will be no more death, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore. In Revelations 22:4, we are told we will see the face of God and we will be with him forever. That has always fascinated me, because I know most of us are looking for something great, many of us are on a wild goose chase for something that will blow us away. We are always looking for that experience that will take our breath away. This is it, to see the face of God and still be alive.

But sadly, this hope is not for everybody. In 1 Corinthians 15:21 & 22 we are told that sin entered the world through one man and with this came death as well. In Genesis the bible tells us that God created the world, and he said everything he created was beautiful. There was no death, there was no pain, and there was no chaos. He then created man in his own image to have dominion and authority over everything he has created. Just as he gave authority to man to rule, he also wanted man to know that he did so under authority and so he gave a command not to eat from a particular tree. God told man that the day he ate from the tree he will die.

This was not only a physical death, it was spiritual death first and foremost. A life lived in separation from God in pain and torment forever. Man disobeyed God and sided with the devil, believing the lie over the loving and gracious care of God. Through Adam's disobedience sin entered the world, and with sin came death. Man became an enemy of God.

There are some who vehemently protest why Adam's sin should become their sin. But my answer to that is, really? Every personal sin we commit is actually rebellion against God. We sin because that's who we are.

We are sinners, not because we sin. Rather, we sin because we are sinners.¹

But that is not the end of the story, John 3:16 tells us God looked at the depravity of man, and his loving heart was moved with compassion. He sent his Son into the world to reconcile the runaway man to Himself. There are two things Jesus accomplished. He lived a perfect life as a man. He obeyed perfectly all the commands of God. The one we could not obey. Then he also went on to pay the penalty that was hanging over our heads as enemies of God.

So here we have two things, the perfect life of Jesus, and the payment for sin. And God has said anyone who will come, Jesus' payment will be credited to them and His perfect record will be theirs as well. What an awesome invitation!

However, this invitation is not open ended, because God has appointed a time when everyone will give an account of all that they have done with their lives. We will all appear before the judgment seat of God, and at that time Jesus will not be a saviour, he will be a judge (John 3:36).

Christ has risen and it is the reason for our hope. To those who have come to know Him as their Saviour, He will return not to die again but to receive us to Himself and we will be with Him in all eternity. To those who don't know Him, that day will be a day

¹ R.C. Sproul, *Essential Truths of The Christian Faith*, [Kindle Edition]

of terror and gnashing of teeth. He will come as a judge. Are you ready to meet Him?

SEVEN THE CERTAINTY OF THE RESURRECTION

By Kwesi Sena, Read [Online](#)*

[1 Corinthians 15:35-58](#)

Recently, in a conversation with a friend, we spoke soberly about the universality of death and how all of us are confronted by its reality, whether great or small, young or old, male or female, rich or poor; we are all subjected to the power of this great enemy.

With every passing day each of us gets closer to the grave. I have a friend who is not particularly excited when you wish him a happy birthday. According to him, every birthday reminds him that he is getting closer to the grave. So for him there is nothing happy about a birthday.

However, as tragic and universal as death is, it is not the most important puzzle to solve. Considering the fact that the soul doesn't die; the most important questions we should be asking are;

- (i) What happens when I die?
- (ii) If my soul lives on, where will it be?
- (iii) Will it be in a happy place?
- (iv) Where will God be when I die?
- (v) Will I see God?
- (vi) Will I meet my friends in the afterlife?

Every religion has something to say about death and what happens when we die. Buddhism and Hinduism believe that after death one is reborn into another body. Existence, they believe, is a cycle of birth, life, death and rebirth. They also believe that depending on your deeds in one's previous life, they will be born in one of six realms. If you've been good in your previous life, you get to be reborn as higher specie in your next life. The ultimate goal is to enter nirvana (their form of heaven) and escape the cycle of life.

Islam also teaches the continued existence of the soul. They believe that on the last day Allah will recreate the decayed bodies of all dead people and then there will be judgment. Some believe all Muslims will eventually go to heaven. Those who did some bad things in life may be punished for a while in hell and eventually go to heaven.

Equally, like all these religions, Christianity also believes in life after death. However what sets Christianity apart from all the others is that we believe in a personal Saviour who died and was resurrected. So the Christian's belief about life after death is not mere speculation. I am yet to meet a Buddhist or a Hindu who can tell me what species they were in their previous life. They have no idea because their belief about life after death is pure speculation.

I will like to examine the Christian's hope of resurrection through the eyes of the first century

believers at Corinth. Paul had received a letter from the church in Corinth about various matters, some very disturbing. There was division in the church, cases of sexual immorality, confusion over the Lord's Supper, disagreement over the gifts of the Holy Spirit, particularly speaking in tongues, and the list goes on.

Now, one source of confusion was about the resurrection of the dead. Living in a Greco-Roman culture which had weird views about life after death, it was possible their belief in the life after death was getting influenced by the prevailing wisdom rather than the Bible. The Greek belief in the life after death ranged from nonexistence to a shadowy and immaterial existence in an underworld.

Some people in the church believed that by the gift of the Spirit, and especially the manifestation of tongues, they had already entered into their spiritual, "heavenly" existence. The body was just a hindrance waiting to be done away with at death. They had therefore denied the body in the present, and had no use for it in the future. That pretty much explains why there was sexual immorality of various kinds in the church. With such a distorted view, it didn't matter what they did with their bodies.

Paul, addresses this particular sin saying,

“...The body is not meant for sexual immorality, but for the Lord, and the Lord for the body. And God raised the Lord and will also raise us up by his power. Do you not know that your bodies are members of Christ? Shall I then take the members of Christ and make them members of a prostitute? Never! Or do you not know that he who is joined to a prostitute becomes one body with her? For, as it is written, “The two will become one flesh.” But he who is joined to the Lord becomes one spirit with him. Flee from sexual immorality. Every other sin a person commits is outside the body, but the sexually immoral person sins against his own body. Or do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit within you, whom you have from God? You are not your own, for you were bought with a price. So glorify God in your body.” (1 Corinthians 6:13-20).

You see, their view of the resurrection had huge ramifications for their present life. And it does for us as well. In 1 Corinthians 15:35-38, Paul sets out to help them renew their minds about the resurrection of the body and how that should affect how they lived.

Paul first and foremost appeals to the resurrection of Christ as the basis for the Christian’s own resurrection. “Now if Christ is proclaimed as raised from the dead, how can some of you say that there is no resurrection of the dead?”(v.12). There is a chain of consequences for such a denial, “If there is no resurrection of the dead, then not even Christ has

been raised. And if Christ has not been raised, then our preaching is in vain and your faith is in vain.” (vv.13-15).

The correlation for Paul was very clear. As compelling as such an argument is, there were people who could still not wrap their heads around it. Yes they believed Christ has been raised from the dead. But that is Christ, what about us, how could that happen? Right in verse 35, we see what the confusion was in Corinth. They could not understand it, and that means it cannot be true. That’s the problem with many of us even today. We measure truth by our ability to understand it. If we cannot understand something we conclude that it cannot be true.

We limit the power of God by our finite minds. For many, the idea that Jesus the Son of God could die to save sinners doesn’t sit too well in their finite minds, and that is what has kept them from accepting Him as their personal Saviour.

The Resurrection And The Natural World

Paul draws an analogy from the natural world of agriculture to paint a picture of the resurrection. “What you sow does not come to life unless it dies” (v.36). Besides the fact that the seed must first die, Paul also emphasises that the final product is totally different from what is originally planted: “And what you sow is not the body that is to be, but a bare kernel, perhaps of wheat or of some other grain.

But God gives it a body as he has chosen, and to each kind of seed its own body.” (vv37-38). He further appeals to the different kinds of bodies that exist in nature, how the human body differs from that of animals or birds or the fish. Then in vv.40-41 he makes allusion to the galaxies “There are heavenly bodies and earthly bodies, but the glory of the heavenly is of one kind, and the glory of the earthly is of another. There is one glory of the sun, and another glory of the moon, and another glory of the stars; for star differs from star in glory.”

From everyday natural experiences he draws lesson for the reasonableness and certainty of the bodily resurrection of the Christian (vv.42-44). Further, Paul compares this to our natures both in the first Adam and the last Adam who is Christ: “Thus it is written, “The first man Adam became a living being”; the last Adam became a life-giving spirit. But it is not the spiritual that is first but the natural, and then the spiritual. The first man was from the earth, a man of dust; the second man is from heaven. As was the man of dust, so also are those who are of the dust, and as is the man of heaven, so also are those who are of heaven. Just as we have borne the image of the man of dust, we shall also bear the image of the man of heaven.”(45-49).

The First Adam And The Last Adam

In our first Adamic nature we are like the seed that is planted, we must first die to attain the new nature which is after the order of the last Adam. We will

have the same kind of body Jesus had when he was raised from the dead, the perishable for imperishable, dishonour for glory, weakness for power and natural for spiritual. Spiritual here is not referring to a ghost-like or immaterial form. We will have real bodies, except that this body will be pure and holy, not susceptible to decay and corruption. Just as Jesus had a physical body after his resurrection and could be touched and seen, we will also have recognisable bodies after our resurrection. There will be both continuity and transformation.

The resurrection is a work God does: “God gives it [the seed] a body as he has chosen, and to each kind of seed its own body.” When we consider the fact that it is God who works out all of this in creation, there should be no doubt that he is also able to accomplish this in us. A denial of the resurrection is a direct denial of the power of God. So regardless of what the Corinthians believed about the power of the Holy Spirit, the show-off of spiritual gifts and their elaborate “churchianity”, their beliefs about the resurrection was anti-Christian. Like the Corinthians, is it possible that we ourselves have denied the resurrection, perhaps not with words but with our actions?

*Online title is Resurrection Of The Body